INDEPENDENT REVIEW · PHONES WITHOUT ACCOUNTS

Blind reproduction and critique of the brief's key claims

15 October 2026 · Reviewer: a separate AI agent (Claude), not the one that helped write the analysis. It received only the raw World Bank Findex 2025 microdata file, the variable codes and a list of claims. It did not see the SQL, code or brief, and wrote its own code from scratch.

Result: all eight claims reproduced within 0.5 points

Ethiopia sample: 1,001 adults; 703 phone owners; 192 phone owners with no account.

#	Claim	Claimed	Reproduced
1	Account ownership, weighted / unweighted	48.8 / 58.7	48.8 / 58.7
2	Phone ownership	58.1	58.1
3	Has a phone, no account (all adults)	19.8	19.8
4	No account, among phone owners	34	34.0 (CI 29–39)
5	No account by income fifth	30–38	29.8–37.8
5	Primary or less / secondary	42 / 17	41.9 / 16.6
5	Rural / urban	39 / 19	39.3 / 18.8
5	Ages 15–24	48	47.5 (CI 39–56)
6	Basic phone / says "lack money"	84 / 82	83.9 / 81.8
7	Kish effective n / design effect	591 / 1.69	591.2 / 1.69
8	Ethiopia highest of 35 on "account but no digital payment"	~58	57.7 (next: Comoros 37.7)
8	35-country population-weighted figure	~13	13.1

On claim 8: 13.1% comes from rescaling each country's weights over all adults. Rescaling over account holders only gives 14.3%. The reviewer judged the first method correct.

Critique

- **"Barely changes with income" was overclaimed.** Each income fifth has only 60–126 effective cases, so each interval is about ±8 to ±12 points. Poorest vs richest differs by 5.7 points (±14.5). The data cannot rule out an income gap of around 15 points. Suggested wording: "no clear income gradient detected."
- **The schooling, place and age gaps hold up:** schooling 25.4 points (±8.1), rural vs urban 20.5 (±9.7), ages 15–24 vs older 20.7 (±9.7).
- **The urban figure is thin:** 160 phone owners (about 91 effective), so 19% means roughly 11–27%.
- **These are one-at-a-time comparisons.** Schooling, place and age overlap. Even so, the rural–urban gap stays when schooling is held fixed: 47 vs 25 (primary or less) and 20 vs 9 (secondary), though some cells have about 65 cases.
- **The age finding is odd:** young adults have more schooling yet the highest rate. Possibly age rules or ID, not schooling. Worth a sentence.
- **The tertiary group** (1.3% on 49 cases) should be flagged as too small to read.
- **Intervals are a minimum.** The Kish method counts unequal weights only, not clustering or stratification, which the public file doesn't include.
- **The 84% basic-phone figure needs a baseline:** 65% of phone owners who have an account also use a basic phone.
- **The 82% "lack money" figure** comes from 192 cases (CI about 75–89), and respondents could give more than one reason.

Not checked: full design-based standard errors (no strata or cluster variables in the file), and any claim not listed above.

What I changed in response

> - Income: the brief now says income "shows no clear pattern, though small groups can't rule out a gap." The heading, methods note and cover letter were changed to match.
> - Basic phones: 84% is now shown against the 65% baseline for phone owners with an account.

- Added caveats: the urban figure rests on 160 phone owners; age rules or missing ID may explain part of the young-adult rate. The tertiary group was already flagged as too small.
- Kept: the intervals note already said they are a lower bound on uncertainty.

Why an AI reviewer: I had no second analyst available. A separate agent with no access to my work is a weaker check than a human peer, but it's an honest one, and every number above can be rerun from the public file.